For the Indian government in 1920, the main issue when it came to Bolshevism was not so much the latter's military capabilities but its subversive activities. In India, the threat of Bolshevik propaganda creating unrest among the population was particularly great when combined with nationalist and pan-Islamist agitation. One of the key challenges facing the Indian government in 1920, then, was the prevention of Bolshevik agents and propaganda from infiltrating India through Afghanistan. Immediately upon gaining independence of their foreign relations in 1919, the Afghan government had invited a Bolshevik mission to Kabul, headed by Karl Bravin, the former Soviet envoy to Persia.[77] Indeed, the British agent in Kabul complained how Bravin and his cohort could be seen riding around the city in a particularly nice coach lent by the emir himself, while the British were assigned a much more inferior mode of transportation.[78]

Despite appearances, however, there was reason to believe that the relationship between Soviet Russia and Afghanistan was not as solid as either nation would like India to think. On 24 August 1919, British intelligence intercepted a message from Bravin to Tashkent, informing his government that:

Afghan policy towards Russia is now absolutely clear. Amir only desired our friendship for security of his northern frontier...He has invited us to his palace merely that we may become hostages. Of course Amir uses us as a bogey to frighten British by threats of alliance with us, and will show us at Kabul as evidence of his power.[79]

For all his flirting with the Soviet government, it seemed that the emir did not entirely trust the new Russian regime. In the autumn of 1919, with the defeat of the hostile Cossack forces at Orenburg, the Soviet regime at Tashkent had finally been able to turn its attention to the Bokharan and Khivan states. By April 1920, Russian forces had facilitated the collapse of the Khanate of Khiva and the establishment of the Khorezm People's Soviet Republic in its place. By the end of the year Bokhara would have followed suit. On both occasions, the Bolsheviks claimed to be helping to 'liberate'